INDO-PAK TIES

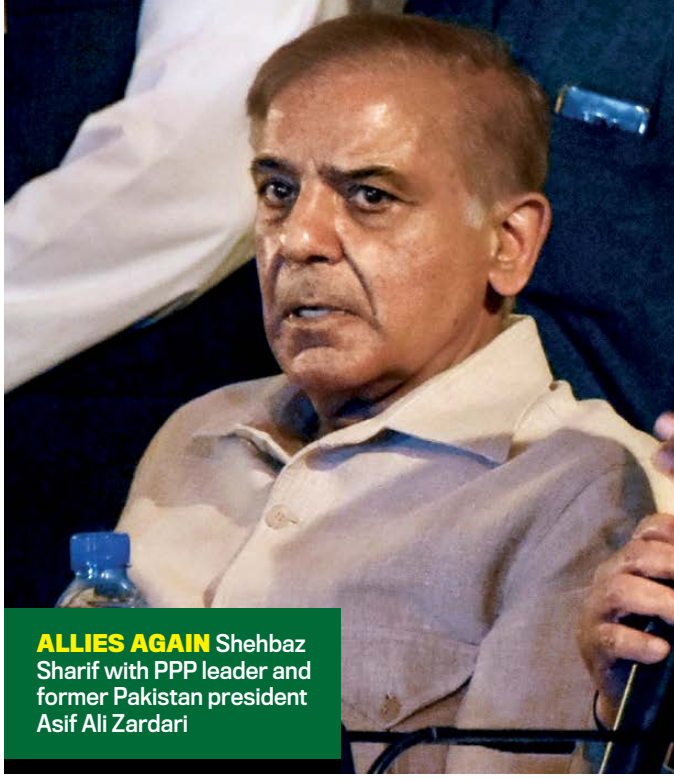
WAIT AND WATCH

Since Pakistan downgraded ties when India abrogated Art. 370, Islamabad has to make the move to restore them

The Sharif brothers—Nawaz and Shehbaz—have been known to push for friendly ties with India. Even though they are back in power, all major foreign policy initiatives will be determined by the Pakistan army, as is the norm. For a while, when former army chief Gen. Qamar Javed Bajwa was in charge of the Establishment, he had surprised even the political class by advocating peace in the neighbourhood, including better ties with India, and talked of fighting extremism and eliminating terrorism. Pakistan downgraded ties with India after the abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019, angrily expelling India's high commissioner in Islamabad, suspending trade ties, severing all transport links and banning all cultural exchanges, including the screening of Indian films and dramas in their country. In March 2021, though, Gen. Bajwa took a seemingly conciliatory turn when he told the gathering at the Islamabad Security Dialogue, "It is time to bury the past and move forward. But for the resumption of the peace process or meaningful dialogue, our neighbour will have to create a conducive environment, particularly in Indian Occupied Kashmir."

For India, there are two major prerequisites to resume dialogue—that Pakistan turn off its terror tap and also drop any demand for restoration of Art. 370 in Jammu and Kashmir, since India saw it as a purely internal matter. And though India considers every new Pakistan government and military dispensation as an opportunity to improve ties, Indian experts say Gen. Asim Munir—who has been army chief since November 2022—has yet to reveal his approach on relations with India. Also, since it was Pakistan that downgraded ties with India, the ball is now in Islamabad's court. India is content to wait and watch. ■

– Bureau reports



ALLIES AGAIN Shehbaz Sharif with PPP leader and former Pakistan president Asif Ali Zardari

The army realises that political stability is a must for economic recovery, without which its own position may get endangered

In the immediate term, though, there is no possibility that a recalcitrant Imran will be given a free hand to indulge in politics. He has, for instance, nominated as K-P chief minister Ali Amin Gandapur, who is known more as a party thug rather than as someone who delivers. This is being seen mainly as thumbing a nose at the military establishment, since Gandapur is not hugely popular within the party and is accused of being involved in the May 9 riots as well. Long-time observers of Pakistan's political scene believe that, without any out-of-the-ordinary developments, political temperatures will eventually simmer down. The task for the PTI in such a situation will be to sustain itself until it next gets a chance at the polls.

GEN. MUNIR'S TASK

To some, the current political scenario may seem like a powder-keg for the Establishment. And certainly the widespread resentment of political parties will require some careful handling. But in the larger scheme of things, the split mandate is also a godsend for the military's political engineers, since it allows them more